

represented about a quarter of his sample. The study revealed that experts' error rates were clearly many times what they had estimated. His study exposed an expert problem: there was no difference in results whether one had a PhD or an undergraduate degree. Well-published professors had no advantage over journalists. The only regularity Tetlock found was the negative effect of reputation on prediction: those who had a big reputation were worse predictors than those who had none.

But Tetlock's focus was not so much to show the real competence of experts (although the study was quite convincing with respect to that) as to investigate why the experts did not realize that they were not so good at their own business, in other words, how they spun their stories. There seemed to be a logic to such incompetence, mostly in the form of belief defense, or the protection of self-esteem. He therefore dug further into the mechanisms by which his subjects generated *ex post* explanations.

I will leave aside how one's ideological commitments influence one's perception and address the more general aspects of this blind spot toward one's own predictions.

*You tell yourself that you were playing a different game.* Let's say you failed to predict the weakening and precipitous fall of the Soviet Union (which no social scientist saw coming). It is easy to claim that you were excellent at understanding the political workings of the Soviet Union, but that these Russians, being exceedingly Russian, were skilled at hiding from you crucial economic elements. Had you been in possession of such economic intelligence, you would certainly have been able to predict the demise of the Soviet regime. It is not your skills that are to blame. The same might apply to you if you had forecast the landslide victory for Al Gore over George W. Bush. You were not aware that the economy was in such dire straits; indeed, this fact seemed to be concealed from everyone. Hey, you are not an economist, and the game turned out to be about economics.

*You invoke the outlier.* Something happened that was outside the system, outside the scope of your science. Given that it was not predictable, you are not to blame. It was a Black Swan and you are not supposed to predict Black Swans. Black Swans, NNT tells us, are fundamentally unpredictable (but then I think that NNT would ask you, Why rely on predictions?). Such events are "exogenous," coming from outside your science. Or maybe it was an event of very, very low probability, a thousand-year flood, and we were unlucky to be exposed to it. But next time, it will not happen. This focus on the narrow game and linking one's performance to a given script is how the nerds explain the failures of mathematical methods in society. The model was right, it worked well, but the game turned out to be a different one than anticipated.